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Untangling the participation buzz in urban place-making: mechanisms and effects

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ABSTRACT

Place-making is a promising approach to foster strong communities in cities. While participation has always been central to urban place-making, novel approaches such as using co-design and digital technologies change how stakeholders participate in the design of place-making interventions and the potential effect of these interventions. These new approaches open up questions on how participation works in place-making and how it is facilitated to achieve the intended outcomes. Through a literature review, 23 articles were selected and analysed using qualitative analysis informed by program theory. This allows us to understand the goals and workings of participation in place-making and its influence on the place-making itself. Findings include that designers of place-making interventions often do not explicitly consider their participation goal in selecting participatory mechanisms, and that place-making efforts driven by physical space are most effective in achieving impact.

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Place-making; participatory design; neighbourhoods; literature study; program theory

1. Introduction

Place-making is an established approach to improve urban life and enhance social cohesion in neighbourhood communities (Kalandides 2018). The place-making Europe network, for example, unites urban planners, designers, and researchers to ‘accelerate place-making as a way to create healthy, inclusive, and beloved communities’ (Placemaking Europe 2022). Place-making programs and initiatives in urban contexts aim to transfer neighbourhoods from *spaces* to *places* (Harrison and Tatar 2008) where residents feel at home and part of the neighbourhood community (Lepofsky and Fraser 2003; Wood et al. 2019).

Although place-making is a known concept that has been widely studied in urban design literature (Borrup et al. 2021), other research fields (e.g. design and human-computer interaction (Harrison and Tatar 2008)) are becoming interested in this concept due to a strong potential and interest in using digital technologies to facilitate participation in urban planning and development.

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While place-making interventions are very often initiated and implemented from top-down, participation of local stakeholders is central to successful place-making (Kalandides 2018). Scholars (Strydom, Puren, and Drewes 2018) have called for a more democratic and collaborative approaches that support bottom-up place-making initiatives and resident participation based on partnership instead of consultation (Arnstein 1969). Such motivations and reasoning strongly align with the democratic and pragmatic ideals of participatory design (PD) (Schuler and Namioka 1993; Simonsen and Robertson 2013). Echoing Foth (2017), the PD discourse can untangle the participatory element in place-making, to design more effective and inclusive interventions.

At the same time, the use of digital technologies in urban planning is opening up opportunities for new ways for residents to shape place-making interventions. For example, using an in situ mobile phone application to acquire input from residents on how urban space can be improved (Peacock, Anderson, and Crivellaro 2018). Input can also be gathered in the digital space, for example when residents play video games (Álvarez and Duarte 2018) or use immersive technology (Globa, Beza, and Wang 2022) to experience current urban places and design future ones. This has led to the development of concepts such as hybrid or digital place-making to describe participation in place-making processes that include digital technologies (Foth 2017; Gonsalves, Foth, and Amayo Caldwell 2021). Place-making is thus a dynamic and developing concept where co-design and the use of digital technologies are increasingly playing a role in the way residents participate (Cilliers and Timmermans 2014; Foth 2017). We, like Kalandides (2018), believe that these developments can and should lead to new participatory approaches in place-making and open up questions on how these approaches work and how they impact the success of place-making interventions.

Given the increased and intersecting interest into place-making by various research domains, the knowledge is scattered, ranging from urban planning (Ellery and Ellery 2019), sociology (Lan Fang et al. 2016), community building (Teernstra and Pinkster 2016), design (Eggertsen Teder 2019), and Human–Computer Interaction (HCI) (Wood et al. 2019). How do the most recent participatory approaches in place-making work, why are they selected, and how do they influence the place-making outcomes? This paper aims to find an answer to this question by integrating the knowledge from multiple fields through a systematic literature review to find and screen potential research papers. These will then be analysed qualitatively to gain insights into what these new participatory approaches are and how these work in place-making programs to achieve the intended effects.

2. Defining place-making

To inform and scope the literature review, this section defines the main ideas and concepts related to place-making and participation, as well as the theoretical lens of program theory which is used in the analysis.

2.1. *Moving from spaces to places*

Places are spaces that you can remember, that you can care about and make part of your life. The world should be filled with places so vivid and distinct that they can carry significance. Places could bring emotions, recollections, people, and even ideas to mind. (Lyndon 1983, 2)